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Warning Signs of Fall Risk in Older Adults

Know what to look for before a fall happens

Many families don't realize their loved one is at risk until after a fall occurs. This guide helps you recognize the early warning signs — physical, functional, and behavioral — so you can act before it's too late.

PHYSICAL WARNING SIGNS

These are changes you can observe in how your loved one moves and carries themselves:

- Holding onto walls, furniture, or doorframes when walking
- Shuffling steps or a noticeable change in walking pattern
- Sitting down heavily or struggling to rise from a chair
- Frequent complaints of dizziness, lightheadedness, or feeling unsteady
- New bruises — especially on arms, hips, knees, or shins — which may signal unreported falls
- Stooped posture or leaning to one side while standing
- Difficulty stepping over thresholds, curbs, or uneven surfaces

FUNCTIONAL WARNING SIGNS

These are changes in what your loved one is willing or able to do:

- Avoiding activities they used to enjoy — often due to fear of falling
- Trouble opening jars, buttoning clothes, or managing daily tasks independently
- Difficulty swallowing, coughing during meals, or avoiding certain foods
- Getting lost mid-sentence, struggling to find words, or increased confusion
- Withdrawing from social interaction or seeming more anxious than usual
- Taking much longer than before to complete routine tasks
- Refusing to use stairs or avoiding certain rooms in their home

AFTER A STROKE — WATCH CAREFULLY

Stroke survivors face a significantly elevated fall risk. Look for:

- One-sided weakness in arm or leg — even mild weakness affects balance
- Foot drop — the foot doesn't lift fully when walking, causing dragging or tripping
- Impulsivity — moving quickly without pausing to assess stability
- Spatial neglect — not noticing obstacles on the affected side
- Fatigue that comes on quickly during activity

THE MOST OVERLOOKED WARNING SIGN

Fear of falling

Fear of falling is itself a major fall risk factor. When older adults start limiting their activity because they're afraid of falling, their strength and balance deteriorate faster — which actually increases their risk. If your loved one says things like "I'm just being careful" or "I don't really go out much anymore," take it seriously.

WHAT TO DO IF YOU NOTICE THESE SIGNS

- Don't wait for a fall to happen — contact a physical therapist for an evaluation
- Mention specific signs you've noticed to their physician
- Ask about a home safety assessment or fall prevention screening
- Contact Savoy Therapy — no referral needed to start a conversation

Savoy Therapy offers complimentary fall prevention screenings for residents in our partner communities. savoytherapy.com | 217-898-8393